

Rooted FC Youth Activity Day Plan

Organiser notes for a football-themed water infiltration activity day.

Design principle: do not start by telling the young people what they are supposed to learn. Let the games create the experience first. The learning can emerge during the walk back, the judging, and the match-commentary discussion.

Format

NAME FOR THE DAY

Manager's Clipboard

Teams act as football managers. They inspect the pitch, choose tactics, run experiments, and decide where the land needs defenders, midfielders and goal-scorers.

COMPETITION SHAPE

Small teams, simple scores

Split into teams of 4-6. Each team gets a clipboard, team name, score sheet and a patch of ground or tray/mini-slope. Keep scoring visible and playful.

Activities

ACTIVITY	HOW IT WORKS	WINNING CONDITION	NOTES FOR ORGANISERS
Runoff Race	Each team picks or is given one metre of downhill ground. Pour the same amount of water at the top and collect what reaches the bottom.	The team with the most runoff wins this round.	This deliberately rewards the "bad" outcome, which makes the result memorable. Afterward ask: why did that patch lose water fastest?
Penalty Shootout	Use infiltration rings/tin cans in different ground: compacted path, grass, under trees, rough ground. Pour the same amount of water into each ring.	The fastest infiltration time wins.	Use a tape measure for water depth rather than guessing. Three nearby rings per team gives a better average.
Pick the Team	Teams build a mini water-story model using soil, grass, sticks, stones and branches. Branches can become trees; shallow channels can become swales; small hollows can become ponds.	The team with the least water arriving at the bottom wins.	This is the main design game. Let them try ideas. Do not over-correct during the build; the water test gives the feedback.
Match Commentary Walk	On the walk back, teams commentate on the real farm: where Runoff Rovers are attacking, where Leaves United are defending, and where the manager should change tactics.	Best observation, best question, or best practical suggestion.	This is where their input connects to the real project. Capture quotes and ideas if consent/permissions allow.

Morning to Afternoon Arc

MORNING

Play, test, compete

Run the practical games first while energy is high: Runoff Race, Penalty Shootout, Pick the Team, and a short Match Commentary Walk. Keep explanations light.

LUNCH

Eat before explaining

After the activities they may be too excited to listen. Let lunch do the reset. Use the break to gather scores, photos, quotes and the best observations.

AFTER-LUNCH RESET

Link the games to the farm

Briefly replay what happened: where water ran away, where it soaked in, and which team tactics worked. Then connect that to the real project on the farm.

AFTERNOON

Contribute to something real

If season and site allow, plant trees. If not, do another useful project task: mulch or protect young trees, mark possible planting lines, map wet/compacted areas, take repeat photos, prepare stakes/guards, or make signs.

Site Requirements

Water access

All the games need water. The easiest site is near a safe stream or trough where buckets can be filled under supervision. If not, consider stored water, a bowser, or a small solar/battery pump.

Ground variety

The best site has several ground types close together: compacted track, grass, rough vegetation, tree shade, bare soil and a small slope. Some disturbance is useful, as long as the area is safe and agreed with the landowner.

Equipment

- Clipboards, pencils and waterproof score sheets
- Buckets or watering cans with measured volumes
- Tin cans/rings for infiltration tests
- Tape measures and stopwatches
- Trays or marked mini-slope areas if the field site is unsuitable

Safety and permissions

- Named activity lead, first-aider, and agreed adult-to-child supervision ratio
- Safe water collection point and supervised bucket carrying
- Use small measured water volumes so test areas do not become slippery or eroded
- Use smooth-edged rings/cans only; tape or remove sharp edges before the day
- No digging or damming real channels without landowner approval
- Any tools for tree planting or protection should be adult-led with suitable gloves/PPE
- Keep children away from steep banks, deep water, machinery and livestock
- Handwashing plan after soil/water activities
- Photo, quote and video consent plan before capturing children's contributions

Suggested Running Order

1. **Kick-off:** teams, names, clipboards, rules.
2. **Runoff Race:** fast, funny, physical start.
3. **Penalty Shootout:** timed infiltration tests.
4. **Pick the Team:** build and test mini land-management models.
5. **Match Commentary Walk:** observe the real farm while the game language is fresh.
6. **Lunch:** eat, settle, gather the scores and best observations.
7. **Reset:** link the morning games to the real project in a short grounded discussion.
8. **Afternoon contribution:** tree planting if suitable, or another practical project task.
9. **Final whistle:** share best observations, award small prizes, and name what changed because of the group.

Organiser reminder: keep the explanation light during the games. The point is to make water movement visible, competitive and memorable. The science can be named afterward.

Prepared as a practical activity outline linked to the Rooted FC water education handout.